> The Afghans also brought quantities of firewood and long poles, with combustibles at the ends, which they deposited under the walls in readiness to burn down my door.

Some of Mackenzie's sawars now embarked on 'a sort of half-mutiny', planning to escape on horseback. 'This I quelled by going down amongst them with a double-barrelled gun. I cocked it, and ordered them to shut the gate, threatening to shoot the first man who should disobey. They saw I was quite determined, for I had made up my mind to die, and they obeyed.' By the evening Mackenzie and his men were exhausted, after 'fighting and working for nearly forty hours without rest'.

> Abandoned, as I evidently was, to almost certain destruction by my own countrymen, my Afghan followers remained staunch to the last, in spite of the most tempting offers if they would betray me. When at last we had scarcely a round of ammunition, Hasan Khan [the commander of Mackenzie's Afghan jezailchi troops] came to me and said: 'I think we have done our duty. If you consider it necessary that we should die here, we will die, but I think we have done enough.'[49]

Mackenzie then agreed to make arrangements for a retreat. It was Ramazan, so they planned their escape soon after sunset, to coincide with the time that their besiegers would be busy with their *iftar* dinner. The Afghan marksmen of Hasan Khan's jezailchis were to lead, while the wounded were to be transported on makeshift litters and were to follow with the women and children. Mackenzie was himself to bring up the rear. The plan was to avoid all villages and to follow the canal until the cantonment came in sight, and then to strike out across the fields. All baggage and food supplies were to be abandoned.[50]

This was easier to order than to achieve. 'A night retreat is generally disastrous,' wrote Mackenzie,

> and this proved no exception, for notwithstanding my strict order that all the baggage should be left behind, many of the poor women contrived to slip out with loads of their little property on their shoulders, making their children walk, whose cries added to the danger of discovery. Going among the women to see that my order for leaving everything was obeyed, a young Gurkha girl of sixteen or eighteen, who had girded up her loins and stuck a sword in her cumberbund came to me, and throwing all that she possessed at my feet, said: 'Sahib you are right, life is better than property.' She was a beautiful creature, with a fair complexion and large dark eyes, and she stood there with her garments swathed around her, leaving her limbs free, a picture of life, spirit and energy. I never saw her again, and fear she was either killed or taken prisoner on the night march.